

Marx then wrote that, “the railway system will, therefore, become, in India, truly the forerunner of modern industry.” The last statement seemed to be somewhat optimistic, as India’s great industrial evolution was late in coming, bogged down as it was by the demands of a colonial power that sought to promote its own economic interests. Workshops and machine shops set up to effect repairs were well-equipped to build locomotives, yet railway companies almost always “bought British”. Railway employers preferred Europeans instead of natives in senior positions.

The iron and steel industry grew, but in fits and starts, until World War I when, in the middle of extreme shortages, the Government turned to Indian steel in order to meet demand. Technological development and modern industry were mere by-products of the railways in India.